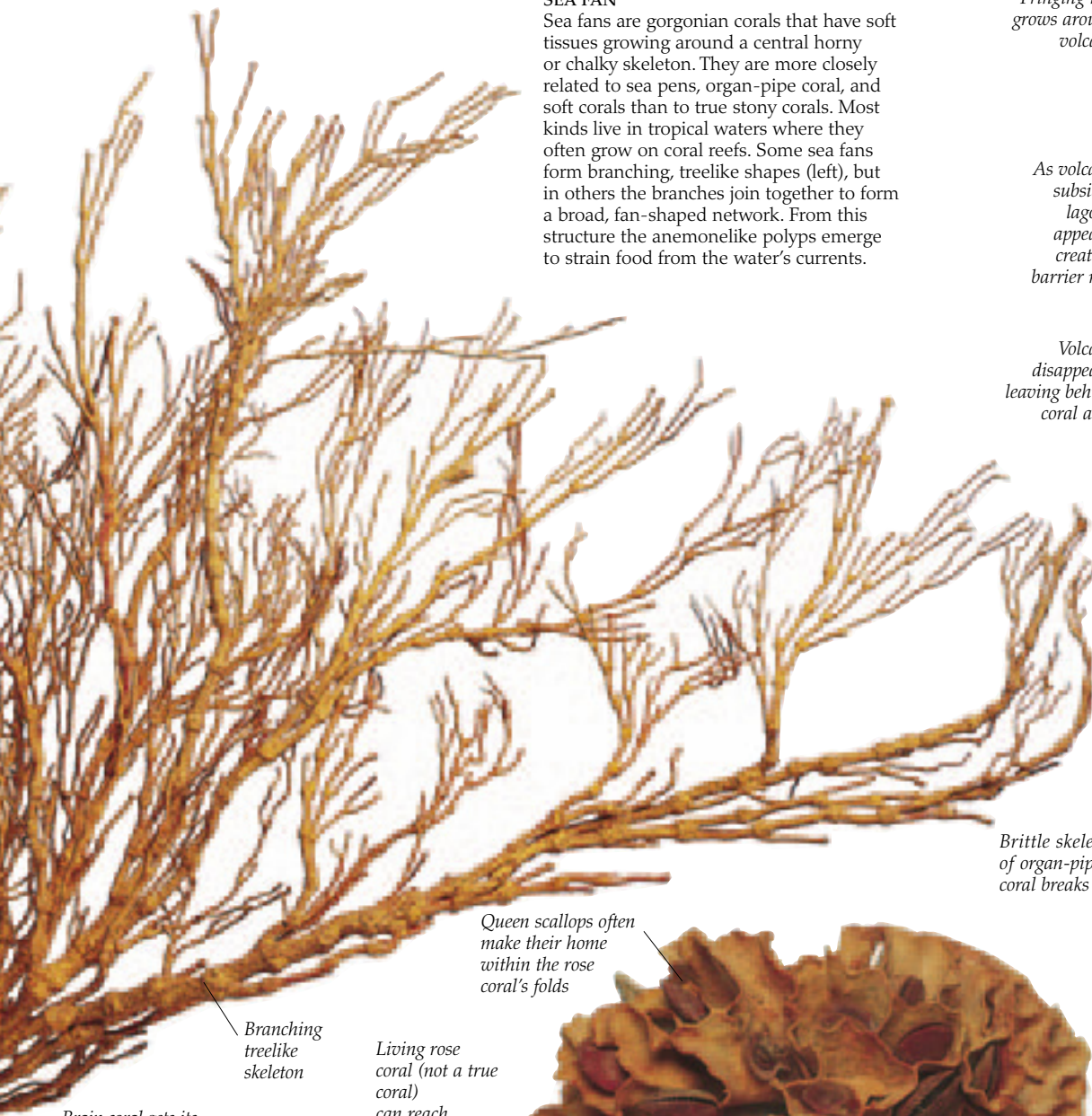
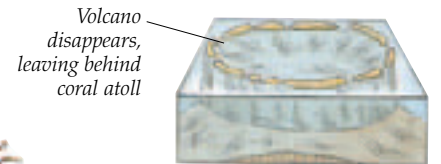
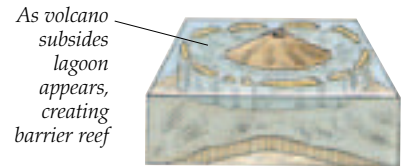
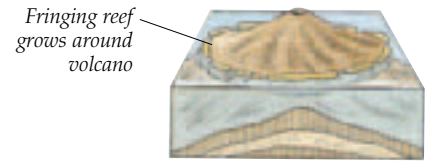




SEA FAN
Sea fans are gorgonian corals that have soft tissues growing around a central horny or chalky skeleton. They are more closely related to sea pens, organ-pipe coral, and soft corals than to true stony corals. Most kinds live in tropical waters where they often grow on coral reefs. Some sea fans form branching, treelike shapes (left), but in others the branches join together to form a broad, fan-shaped network. From this structure the anemone-like polyps emerge to strain food from the water's currents.



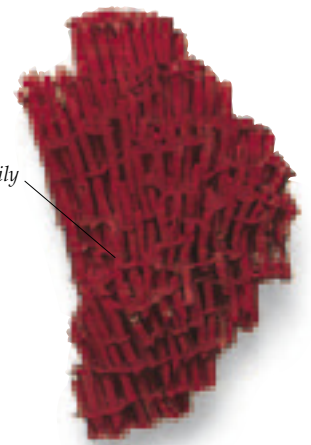
ATOLL IN THE MAKING
An atoll is a ring of coral islands formed around a central lagoon. Charles Darwin (1809–82) thought atolls were formed by a reef growing around a volcanic island which then subsided beneath the surface, a theory later proved to be correct.

Queen scallops often make their home within the rose coral's folds

Living rose coral (not a true coral) can reach 20 in (50 cm) in diameter



Brittle skeleton of organ-pipe coral breaks easily



ORGAN PIPES

Dull green-colored tissue covers the bright red skeleton of living organ-pipe coral. Its anemone-like polyps emerge from each of the tiny pipes in the skeleton. Organ-pipe coral is not a true stony coral, but a relative of sea fans, soft coral, and sea pens.

A CORAL BY ANY OTHER NAME

Rose coral is moss animal and grows in colonies on the seabed. Each colony is made of millions of tiny animals, each living in one unit in its leaflike structure.

BIGGEST AND BEST
Here Australia's Great Barrier Reef shows fish feeding on plankton. Over 1,200 miles (2,000 km) long, it is the largest structure in the world made by living organisms. Of the 400 kinds of coral, many spawn on the same night after a full Moon, the water resembling an underwater snowstorm.



STONE BRAIN

Living brain coral's surface is covered with soft tissue. Anemone-like polyps grow in rows along the channels in its skeleton. Brain corals are slow-growing stony corals, increasing in width just over an inch each year.

Brain coral gets its name from its convoluted surface that looks like a human brain

Branching treelike skeleton

